North Star OKR Template

For Executive Leadership Teams

About The Template

An easy-to-implement guide for Exec Teams as they craft their annual North Star OKRs.

Includes:

- A Readiness Exercise
- 8 Guided Exercises
- Extra Resources

The Goal

At the end of this process, an Exec Team will have a complete set of annual North Star OKRs that you can share with the rest of the organization. Everyone in your organization will use these North Star goals to align, prioritize, and drive meaningful progress on their day-to-day work.

Starting Point

Before you being using this template, make sure the Executive Team can answer the following questions:

- ☐ What is our maximum number of North Star OKRs for the upcoming year?
- ☐ What are the layers of our organization that will use OKRs?
    - 1 - Executive Layer
    - 2 - Broad Strategic Layer (usually large and cross-functional)
    - 3 - Specialized Teams
    - 4 - Individual
- ☐ Have we scheduled a 2-hour meeting for the ELT to draft North Star OKRs?
- ☐ Have we determined our meeting facilitator?
- ☐ Have we asked ELT members to come to the meeting prepared with a shortlist of their priorities and initiatives, based on the organization's overall strategy?

Setting Overall Strategy

Pre-prep work

- Before setting your annual North Star OKRs, take time to align on your overarching strategy. Ask yourselves: What unique approach will move us forward — what we'll prioritize, what we'll do differently, and what we'll deliberately choose not to do?
- This step bridges your Mission (your purpose) and your OKRs (how you'll define success), and will anchor the priorities you choose for the year ahead.
- Timeline: Strategy typically spans 1–3 years and shapes how your organization will compete, grow, and focus its efforts.

Mission	**What is your purpose?**
Strategy	**What is your unique approach?**
OKRs	**How will you define success?**
Action Plans	**What will you do?**

Crafting North Star OKRs

Quick Review

OKRs are an expression of strategic focus. They tell teams what success looks like.

OKRs stand for Objective and Key Results.

- Objectives are the WHAT I want to accomplish.
- Key Results are HOW I will accomplish it.

Exercise 1

Brainstorm Priorities

What is most important this year?

- Each participant writes down up to 5 strategic priorities on digital or physical Post-Its.
- Determine what is the maximum number of North Stars you will allow this year (less than 5). If extra help is needed, check out our Resources.

Exercise 2

Group By Theme

Are there any themes here?
Are any items related that we could group together?

- Gather Post-Its by theme on a wall; if virtual, in Mural or other collaborative software.
- If extra help is needed, check out our Resources.

Exercise 3

Prioritize and Focus

What are our "North Star" priorities?

- Select no more than 5 priorities for the next 12 months.
- Remember: usually, less is more.
- If extra help is needed, check out our Resources.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

Exercise 4

Turn Priorities into Objectives

Success Criteria

- Aim for each Objective to be 10 words or less.
- Each should include a verb.
- Avoid including metrics.
- If extra help is needed, check out our Resources.

Priority 1: _____ → Objective 1: _____

_____

Priority 2: _____ → Objective 2: _____

_____

Priority 3: _____ → Objective 3: _____

_____

Exercise 5

Improve Your Objectives

Review each Objective as a group:

- Can you make the Objective more specific?
- Can the Objective be more action-oriented?
- Can you frame it more concisely?
- Can you make it more memorable?

- Still unclear? Consider this example of how to revise an Objective:
  - Start with: *Climbing a mountain in the Himalayas*
  - Make it more significant and concrete → *Summit K2 this year*
  - Make it more action oriented and inspirational → *Break the record summiting K2 this* year

- If extra help is needed, check out our Resources.

Objective 1: [Insert Revised Key Objective] _____

Objective 1: [Insert Revised Key Objective] _____

Objective 1: [Insert Revised Key Objective] _____

Exercise 6

Draft Org-Wide Key Results

Success Criteria:

- Aim for each Key Result to be 10 words or less.
- Confirm they are not To-Do's or tasks.
- Limit to no more than 5 KR's for each Objective
- If extra help is needed, check out our Resources.

O1: [Insert Objective]

- KR1: [Insert Key Result] _____
- KR2: [Insert Key Result] _____
- KR3: [Insert Key Result] _____
- KR4: [Insert Key Result] _____
- KR5: [Insert Key Result] _____

O2: [Insert Objective]

- KR1: [Insert Key Result] _____
- KR2: [Insert Key Result] _____
- KR3: [Insert Key Result] _____
- KR4: [Insert Key Result] _____
- KR5: [Insert Key Result] _____

O3: [Insert Objective]

- KR1: [Insert Key Result] _____
- KR2: [Insert Key Result] _____
- KR3: [Insert Key Result] _____
- KR4: [Insert Key Result] _____
- KR5: [Insert Key Result] _____

Exercise 7

Improve Key Results

Review each key result as a group:

- To improve a Key Result, answer the following prompts:
  - What do we need to be doing differently next year than we are doing today to achieve this objective?
  - Which metrics would tell us we're on track with this goal?
  - Which of these are interdependent/intertwined?
  - Could any of these be combined into a single/more complex metric?
    e.g. stable donor flow, engagement rate, or constant presence in the national news?
  - If we achieve all of these 100% are we certain we'll achieve the goal? If not, what's missing?
- If extra help is needed, check out our Resources

O1: [Insert Objective]

- KR1: [Insert Revised Key Result] _____
- KR2: [Insert Revised Key Result] _____
- KR3: [Insert Revised Key Result] _____
- KR4: [Insert Revised Key Result] _____
- KR5: [Insert Revised Key Result] _____

O2: [Insert Objective]

- KR1: [Insert Revised Key Result] _____
- KR2: [Insert Revised Key Result] _____
- KR3: [Insert Revised Key Result] _____
- KR4: [Insert Revised Key Result] _____
- KR5: [Insert Revised Key Result] _____

O3: [Insert Objective]

- KR1: [Insert Revised Key Result] _____
- KR2: [Insert Revised Key Result] _____
- KR3: [Insert Revised Key Result] _____
- KR4: [Insert Revised Key Result] _____
- KR5: [Insert Revised Key Result] _____

Exercise 8
Final Review

Congratulations!
You've crafted your North Star OKRs. Before you share them with the rest of the organization:

- ☐ Compare your OKRs to your Org Chart. The closer they are, the more suspect.
- ☐ Conduct the Pause for Equity.
- ☐ Ask if you are all prepared to prioritize company resources to achieve each of these Objectives this year.
- ☐ Set a deadline for requesting an amendment to the North Star OKRs.
  Not to exceed 48 hours.
- ☐ Appoint (and thank) the leader of your OKR program for kicking off next steps.

Next Steps…

Once you have committed to your North Star OKRs…

1. Set up sharable doc with OKRs
2. Schedule OKR shepherd meeting
3. Pick one tool to make OKRs accessible to everyone.
4. Lock your OKRs for the next cycle within 3 weeks
5. Designate OKR owners.
6. Track progress at least monthly.
7. Grade and reflect at the end of each cycle.

Resource Center

- *What's an OKR? Definitions and Examples*
- *OKRs Explained! Our free course*
- *Discussion Playbook* (how to resolve conflicts/misalignment through productive dialog)
- *Our other templates*
- *Find the Why of Your Company*
- *The Value of a North Star OKR*